

Trump tries to seed Iran uprising

He pledges U.S. help for Kurds to seize territory and overthrow regime

BY KAREN DEYOUNG, MUSTAFA SALIM, ELLEN NAKASHIMA AND WARREN P. STROBEL

The Trump administration, bracing for more U.S. casualties and considering whether to put troops on the ground in Iran, has begun reaching out to Tehran's domestic opposition as potential allies to foment an uprising against the regime.

In calls this week to Kurdish minority leaders in Iran and neighboring Iraq, President Donald Trump offered "extensive U.S. air cover" and other backing for anti-regime Iranian Kurds to take over portions of western Iran, according to multiple people familiar with the effort.

"The American request to the Iraqi Kurds is to open the way and not obstruct" Iranian Kurdish groups mobilizing in Iraq, "while also providing logistical support," said a senior official of the Patriotic Union of Kurdistan, one of two major political parties that govern Iraq's semi-autonomous Kurdish region.

"Trump was clear in his call" Sunday to PUK leader Bafel Talabani. "He told us the Kurds must choose a side in this battle — either with America and Israel or with Iran," said the official, one of several Kurdish and U.S. officials who discussed sensitive matters on the condition of anonymity.

A senior official of the Kurdish Democratic Party, the other major Iraqi party whose leader, Masoud Barzani, was also called by Trump, confirmed that account, but said that "it's not about who has more active armed militias" ready to move into Iran, "it's about who has more support from inside."

Trump also spoke Tuesday with Mustafa Hijri, head of the

SEE IRAN ON A12

Israel



LEO CORREA/AP

A site in central Israel struck by a missile Thursday. Iranian retaliatory attacks appeared to lessen in volume in recent days.

Iraq



HADI MIZBAN/AP

Funerals are held Thursday in Baghdad for fighters from the Popular Mobilization Forces killed in a strike in Babil province.

Nations across globe cut off from crucial energy source

BY EVAN HALPER AND ANTHONY FAIOLA

Countries across Europe and Asia are facing a potential energy crisis after an Iranian drone strike shut down Qatar's exports of liquefied natural gas this week, cutting off nations from India to Italy from a crucial energy source and potentially increasing costs for key industries in the United States.

Qatar is a linchpin of a global energy system built on LNG, a fossil fuel less polluting than coal that many countries have embraced because it is easy to ship and store, and was sourced from generally stable countries.

Now consumers and businesses from Seoul to Islamabad

to Brussels may face steeply higher energy costs, after an Iranian drone struck Qatar's largest gas liquefaction plant in Ras Laffan, south of Doha on Monday. The strike was part of attacks by Iran on energy infrastructure in Qatar and fellow U.S. ally Saudi Arabia.

Qatar Energy, which produces and exports LNG, said in a statement Monday that it "ceased production" at the facility. On Wednesday, it announced it would not be able to honor export contracts.

It is unclear how long it will take Qatar Energy to repair the plant. Analysts say returning to full production would take two weeks after repairs are complete.

SEE ENERGY ON A12

Iran



MAJID ASGARIPOUR/REUTERS

People in Tehran flee an explosion Thursday. Airstrikes have hit 220 locations in the capital, Mayor Alireza Zakani said.

Lebanon



DANIEL CARDE/GETTY IMAGES

Residents of Beirut's southern suburbs flee after Israel issued a blanket evacuation order for Dahiyeh, a Hezbollah stronghold.

Iranian regime maintains its grip despite heavy losses

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE AND JÚLIA LEDUR

The U.S. and Israeli air campaign against Iran has decimated the highest ranks of political and military leadership, destroyed critical military command-and-control infrastructure and fighting capability, and damaged civilian buildings across the country.

In Tehran, the expanding conflict appears to be frustrating the succession process after Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was killed. Khamenei's funeral was postponed after the group charged with choosing his successor was targeted by Israeli strikes. Following that attack, Iranian state media announced that voting for the next

supreme leader would be conducted remotely.

But so far, some six days into a war that has now touched 12 countries across the Middle East, major military operations have not threatened the Iranian regime's grip on power, according to European and Arab officials briefed on assessments of the regime's standing since the conflict began.

Iran, the officials say, was prepared for this conflict. The command structures built to survive a decapitation strike appear to remain substantially intact, allowing Iranian retaliatory strikes against Israel, Qatar and Bahrain to begin within hours of the initial attacks. And inside the country since the conflict

SEE LEADERSHIP ON A13

Noem booted as head of DHS

MOUNTING CRITICISM IN A DIVISIVE TENURE

Trump chooses Mullin of Oklahoma to replace her

BY MARIANNE LEVINE, ISAAC ARNSDORF, BRIANNA SACKS AND THEODORIC MEYER

President Donald Trump said Thursday that he is replacing Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem, a move that came amid mounting bipartisan criticism of her stewardship of the administration's mass deportation agenda and efforts to dismantle the Federal Emergency Management Agency.

Trump announced the decision on social media and said Noem would be replaced by Sen. Markwayne Mullin (R-Oklahoma), effective at the end of this month. Noem, he said, will move into a new role as "Special Envoy for The Shield of the Americas," which he described as part of a new Western Hemisphere security initiative that will be unveiled at an event in Florida on Saturday.

In his post, Trump praised Noem as having "served us well" and for her "numerous and spectacular results (especially on the Border!)."

Noem has faced increasing uncertainty over whether she would remain in her position as the public soured on her agency's aggressive immigration enforcement and as even some Republicans questioned whether she was fit for the job. Her ouster adds more potential instability to the Department of Homeland Security at a time when the agency remains partially shut down because of an impasse over a funding extension on Capitol Hill, where Democrats are demanding new accountability measures for federal immigration officers.

Noem was attending a conference in Nashville when Trump

SEE NOEM ON A5

Ballroom vote delayed over 'significant public input'

BY JONATHAN EDWARDS AND DAN DIAMOND

A federal planning commission on Thursday delayed a vote on President Donald Trump's planned White House ballroom until next month, citing "significant public input," including tens of thousands of comments, nearly all of them critical of the project.

The National Capital Planning Commission had planned to review the proposal and vote on it — the final procedural hurdle for an effort to dramatically remake one of the most revered symbols of American power and democracy.

But at the start of the meeting, commission chair Will Scharf said the panel would not discuss or vote on the project on Thursday, and instead would take it up at an April 2 meeting. He cited the expected length of testimony from the more than 100 people who had signed up to say what

SEE BALLROOM ON A5

Beijing sets five-year strategy



KEVIN FRAYER/GETTY IMAGES

Delegates in traditional dress leave after the opening session of the National People's Congress in Beijing, the country's top annual political gathering, where China lowered its economic growth target and raised defense spending by 7 percent. Story, A14

A third DHS shooting of a citizen went unnoticed

Year-old records request about the killing was answered last month

BY ROBERT KLEMKO

After the Texas Ranger knocked on her door and delivered the numbing news, Rachel Reyes realized she hadn't thought to ask who shot her son. She figured it had been another Ranger that killed Ruben Ray Martinez, 23, after he allegedly failed to comply with a law enforcement officer's orders.

But a week later, Reyes read an article from a local news outlet in South Padre Island that confused her. The police in that small, South Texas beach community were saying there had been an officer-involved shooting and a man was dead, but a separate, unnamed agency was responsible. Reyes called the Ranger who notified her and was now investigating the shooting: *Who shot*

Ruben?

A Department of Homeland Security agent assigned to immigration enforcement was responsible, the Ranger said.

Reyes didn't go public, instead deciding to await the results of the investigation by the Rangers, who are part of the Texas Department of Public Safety.

The March 15, 2025, killing of Martinez, a U.S. citizen, drew almost no public attention, even as protests erupted over the January shooting deaths of two U.S. citizens in Minneapolis — Renée Good, a mother of three, and Alex Pretti, an ICU nurse. South Padre Island Police put out a press release on Martinez but did not identify the agency responsible for his death. A two-sentence police report described Martinez striking a federal agent with his vehicle but did not mention the shooting that allegedly happened a moment later.

Texas officials, citing their ongoing investigation, declined to release footage of the incident. DHS did not publicly acknowledge

SEE SHOOTING ON A4

IN THE NEWS

ICE facility protest A first-ever trial against an alleged "antifa cell" in Texas accused of orchestrating a left-wing terrorist plot could be a playbook for cracking down on critics. A3

Federal layoffs The White House proposed a rule to streamline firings after last year's cuts were mired in challenges and confusion. A3

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Medical schools will boost training in nutrition, heeding advice from RFK Jr. A8

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A day before the NHL trade deadline, the Caps swapped center Nic Dowd for a pair of draft picks and a prospect. B7

THE REGION

Virginia Democrats prepared competing budgets in the Senate and House that disagree on a few key issues. B13

WEEKEND

In Pixar's "Hoppers," an environmentalist uses a robotic beaver in an effort to save a threatened habitat.

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